# THE ANNOTATION GUIDE

What Goes in an Annotation Set · LAW 575 · Spring 2027 · Professor Haque

Before each session with assigned reading, you post four margin notes in Hypothesis. The notes are how you arrive ready to talk, and they are how I learn where the reading landed and where it did not: I read the margins before class and bring what I find there into the room. This guide says what the four notes are, how they are checked, and what separates a useful note from a thin one.

## The Requirement in Brief

- **Four notes per reading.** The rule, the gut check, the pile-on, and the question. Each is described below.
- **Due by class time.** Post before the session meets. The first set is due by Wednesday, January 13, with the Tech Digest primer, covers Sessions 1 and 2 together as one set, and doubles as the Tech Digest's first component: one posting satisfies both. In Canvas it appears as two assignments with one due date (Session 1, pp. 13-24; Session 2, pp. 25-43); together they are the one set. A set posted late still counts until its close, at 1:15 pm two weeks after its session (or at 1:15 pm on Monday, March 15, if that would fall in spring break), and is recorded as late (the syllabus's late-work rule), though the margins are no use to the room if they arrive after it. The first set is required of everyone and is not one of the four you may skip. Posted late, it counts until 1:15 pm on Wednesday, January 20 (Session 3), and a late first set is one late item, not two; if you add the course after January 13, it is due by 1:15 pm on Monday, January 25, and is not late.
- **Twenty-one sets, seventeen required.** Twenty-two of the twenty-six sessions have Hypothesis reading, and the first set covers Sessions 1 and 2 together, so there are twenty-one sets. Session 8 (the quiz), Session 14 (the workshop), and Session 26 (synthesis) have no reading, and Session 6's reading, the COPPA packet, is annotated as an individual Canvas assignment under the SIAR Module rather than as a Hypothesis set, so it is not one of the twenty-one. Seventeen of the twenty-one sets are required, the first among them, and all twenty-one are required for participation Honors.
- **Checked for completion and good faith.** Annotation sets are never scored or ranked. Write every note yourself: generative AI is barred in every annotation set, the first set included, and using it is an Honor Code matter; ordinary spelling and grammar checking is fine. A set is complete when four notes are posted in good faith on that session's reading. If no classmate's note exists when you post, leave your other three notes by class time and add the pile-on once a classmate has posted, before the set's close; the set is not late on that account. A set is not complete until the fourth note exists.
- **Where.** In Hypothesis, through the course's Canvas site, in the private class group. Your notes are visible to the class, which is the point.

## The Four Notes

**1. The rule.** Quote or point to the operative language, then state the rule in your own words in a sentence or two. Not what the case was about: what the law now is, as this reading leaves it. If the rule has elements, name them. This is the note that pays off in class, because it is the note I am most likely to ask you to read aloud.

**2. The gut check.** Your honest first reaction to the rule, before you decide what the professional answer is. Does it seem right, workable, overbroad, plainly wrong? Policy instincts belong here, where they can warm up without yet having to be an argument. The memo requires legal analysis; the margins do not.

**3. The pile-on.** A reply to a classmate's note. Agree and extend, disagree and say why, answer their question, or supply the counterexample they invited. A set without a pile-on is not complete; if you post first, come back for it once a classmate has posted. The margins are a conversation, and a conversation needs second voices.

**4. The question.** The thing you still do not understand, or the place the reading lost you, stated precisely enough that someone could answer it. "I am confused" is not a question. "The opinion says the statute reaches conduct abroad, but the note on page 104 reads the other way; which governs?" is one.

### THIN AND USEFUL, SIDE BY SIDE

- **Thin.** "Interesting case." "I agree with the court." "Confusing." These are reactions to having read, not notes on what was read.
- **Useful.** "The rule is that an interactive computer service is not treated as the publisher of third-party content, so the question in every § 230 case becomes who authored the material." "This feels backwards to me: the platform chose what to amplify, and amplification looks like editing." "To the note above: the statute's text answers your question, because the exclusion is written in terms of content, not conduct." "Why does the court cite the 1996 findings at all if it reads the text as unambiguous?"

## The Primer Variant (Sessions 1 and 2)

In Sessions 1 and 2, the reading is the technical primer, and the four notes change shape to fit it: paraphrase a dense passage in your own words; invent an analogy a non-technical reader could follow; mark the fog where the material lost you; and pile on to a classmate's thread. Answering someone's fog note is peer teaching, and it is the most valuable thing you can do in those margins. The Tech Digest Project document has the rest.

## Practical Notes

- **Length.** Two or three sentences per note is plenty. Precision matters; volume does not.
- **Placement.** Anchor each note to the passage it is about. A note attached to the right sentence teaches the room where to look.
- **Tone.** Disagree with arguments, never with classmates. The margins carry your professional voice, the same one the memo requires.
- **If you fall behind.** The four sets you are not required to post exist for the weeks life intervenes; an Honors candidate relies on the late-work rule instead, since one late set does not cost Honors. Use them; posting hollow sets to keep a streak helps no one.
- **Trouble posting.** Tell me before class rather than after. If Hypothesis is unavailable, post your four notes to the Session Make-Up Board under Discussions, titled with the session number.

## Course documents

Each link opens the current version: the Circle Guide from the shared course folder, every other document from the course website. The syllabus is the master document and controls where documents differ.

Syllabus. The master document; it controls where documents differ.

Circle Guide. How the portfolio works, from sign-up to circles, the Memo Rubric, the cure cycle, the CREAC template, and the Circle Letter form.

Memo Coversheet & Certification. The cover materials required with every memo.

Tech Digest Project. Instructions and deadlines, from the first session to the reflection due February 1.

Annotation Guide (this document). What goes in an annotation set.

SIAR Module. The Session 6 module and the quiz instructions.

Course website. The course home page: next class, deadlines, and links to every course document; the Unit Circles page is linked from it.

Shared course folder. Where the Circle Guide lives, always the current version.

Canvas course. Modules, assignments, sign-ups, the Session Make-Up Board, and recordings.

## DOCUMENT HISTORY

**OPEN IN v12.1 (unresolved items; each resolves in a numbered revision):**

- Canvas and Hypothesis links: set at deployment in the Spring 2027 course shell.
- Hypothesis class group: created and students enrolled at deployment.

**v12.1 · Oct 19, 2026 · Course documents: every document but the Circle Guide now opens as a PDF from the course website; links updated; a stray link in the appendix removed; no rule changed.**

Earlier versions are kept by the professor; the version above is the one in force.